

Life and Universe in Indian Knowledge System

CONCEPT OF LIFE

- Soul (Atman) is eternal; body is temporary. Every living being has a soul.
- Life continues through birth, death, and rebirth until Moksha (liberation) is attained.
- Human life is especially valuable as it enables spiritual growth.

Four Goals of Life (Purusharthas)

Purushartha	Meaning
Dharma	Righteousness and moral duty – living ethically
Artha	Wealth and material prosperity through proper means
Kama	Desires, happiness, and emotional fulfillment
Moksha	Liberation from the cycle of birth and death

KARMA AND REBIRTH

- Every action has consequences – good actions bring positive results, bad actions bring suffering.
- The soul takes many births; present life is shaped by past actions (karma).
- Moksha ends the cycle of rebirth permanently.

YOGA AND MEDITATION

- Yoga and meditation help control the mind, improve health, and achieve inner peace.
- Considered the path to harmony between body, mind, and soul.

CONCEPT OF THE UNIVERSE

- **Universe is governed by a universal law called: Rta (Cosmic Order)**
- Follows a natural balance – seasons, planetary motion, life cycles all governed by Rta.

Panchamahabhutas – Five Elements

- Earth (Prithvi), Water (Jala), Fire (Agni), Air (Vayu), Space (Akasha)
- Form the human body, nature, and all living and non-living things
- Central to Ayurveda, Yoga, architecture, and spiritual practices

BRAHMAN – UNIVERSAL REALITY

- Brahman = Supreme universal consciousness and ultimate source of the entire universe (from Upanishads)
- Atman (individual soul) is connected with Brahman – key teaching: "Atman is Brahman"

CYCLICAL NATURE OF THE UNIVERSE

- Universe moves in continuous cycles: Creation → Preservation → Destruction → Re-creation
- Symbolized by Brahma (creator), Vishnu (preserver), Shiva (destroyer/transformer)

HARMONY WITH NATURE

- Respect for rivers, forests, mountains, and animals – nature is treated as sacred
- Non-violence (Ahimsa) and sustainable living are central values